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The 'performative' university: theoretical and personal reflections

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ABSTRACT
For centuries, universities have proliferated and flourished around the world, playing an important role in societal knowledge production and diffusion. However, in the past four decades, this old organizational form has been subjected to neoliberal, managerialist policy doctrines such as New Public Management. Following this, universities have tended to become more 'business-like' in their internal management and governance, with generally perceived adverse effects on the quality of academic education, research, and working conditions. These developments pose fundamental threats to academic freedom and free knowledge production and diffusion. Acknowledging various forms of academic resistance to, and coping with, these threats, the purpose of our paper is twofold. First, we adopt the concept of 'performativity' – hitherto researched mainly in primary and secondary schools in Anglo-Saxon contexts – to account for, and critique, neoliberal university policies, and practices in a variety of Global North settings. Second, through collaborative autoethnography, we add our own personal narratives to 'talk back' to managerialism.

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Introduction

With the possible exception of armies, few organizations have the longevity of universities. Bologna and Oxford are generally credited as the world's oldest universities continuously still in operation, originating from the second half of the 12th century (Blockmans 2020). Given their prolonged global proliferation and flourishing and their continuing role in knowledge production and diffusion, universities can reasonably be regarded as a 'successful organizational form' (Engwall 2020, 1).

However, in recent decades, this organizational form has come under increasing scrutiny. Under the influence of neoliberal, managerialist policy doctrines like New Public Management (NPM), public sector organizations (including universities) have been impelled to become more 'business-like,' increasingly overseeing performance and

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accountability through primarily quantitative key performance indicators and financial targets (Chandler, Barry, and Clark 2002; Morgan 2022). Former collegial forms of governance, when and wherever they did prevail, have been largely replaced by authoritarian, top-down 'professional' management (Fleming 2022; Tuchman 2009). Similarly, older academic senate forms of deliberation, again, when and wherever they were present, have given way to instrumentalizing and coercive management policies (Geppert and Hollinshead 2017; Tourish and Willmott 2015). Furthermore, government cutbacks, neo-liberal competitive predilections and market-like governance have increased intra- and inter-university funding competition. This has variously engendered increasing university education and research commercialization, precarity of employment, and a propensity towards business marketing practices (Lynch and Ivancheva 2015). Therein, the business school is the avant-garde of systems and policies being readily embraced across the entire university (Parker 2018).

All of the above is highly problematic. Such neoliberal developments fundamentally threaten academic freedom and overshadow independent knowledge production and diffusion by increasingly placing it under the control of corporate and commercial mindsets and interests (Hall 2018; Manning 2024). This means that only those forms and subjects of education and research are retained which are aligned with these corporate and commercial interests. Other, more traditional practices are relegated, cut back or phased out, sometimes even physically through redundancy (e.g., Hooley 2021; Press 2023). This subjection of academic work to corporate performance management and evaluation policies goes hand-in-hand with the sanitization of academic idea formation (Lynch and Ivancheva 2015; Van Houtum and Van Uden 2022).

Nevertheless, this hollowing out of academic freedom and working conditions has not gone uncontested. Some academics enact overt intellectual activism, 'talking back' to managerialism and the 'audit culture' (Contu 2018; Ruth et al. 2018). Others advocate covert forms of resistance, seemingly complying but simultaneously sabotaging the administrative machine (Anderson 2008; Siltaloppi, Laurila, and Artto 2022; Teelken 2012). And, a number of academics provide spaces for personal reflections on the neoliberal university, to cope with its pressures and to learn self-reflexively and experientially from it (Callahan and Elliott 2020; Kallio et al. 2016).

Earlier, and perhaps more incisively than universities, primary and secondary schools have wrestled with NPM and neoliberal policies and practices, especially in Anglo-Saxon contexts. In order to account for, and to make sense of, these neoliberal policies' effects on work and well-being in schools, Stephen Ball (2000, 2003, 2012) developed the concept of *performativity*, largely building on the work of the French philosopher Jean-François Lyotard (Lyotard [1979] 1984). Following these developments, this paper has two purposes. First, we adopt and explore the concept of 'performativity' and expand it to include universities, and moreover extend the scope from the Anglo-Saxon to the Global North. Second, we contribute to the *corpus* of academics 'talking back' to managerialism by autoethnographically recounting our own stories and experiences, while making sense of them via the performativity concept (McCann et al. 2020; Ruth et al. 2018; Zawadski and Jensen 2020). Thus, we amplify current 'scientific' forms of academic writing with more personal and lived narratives (Gilmore et al. 2019).

In this way, we make several contributions. Theoretically, we supplement the field of performativity theories with the approach by Ball (following Lyotard) that appears tailor-

made for educational and research institutions and as such, according to Blanco and Metcalfe (2020, 785), 'continues to be relevant... although in higher education research, its use to date has been somewhat limited' (exceptions are Dey and Steyaert 2007; Gendron 2008; Jones et al. 2020; Taberner 2018). Empirically, we (Ashok, Max, Peter and Lynne, four late-career academics from Japan, the Netherlands, UK, and USA, respectively) add our original personal narratives to the existing accounts of university life under neoliberal managerialism, enriching the current corpus of academic lived experience (De Coster and Zanoni 2019; Smith and Ulus 2020).

In the next section, we first present the performativity concept as proposed by Ball (following Lyotard) and then discuss existing work in this conceptual light. In the next four sections, we present and discuss our own personal narratives through which we develop an understanding via the performativity concept, which we then connect to the literature. Finally, the paper closes with discussion, conclusions, and some policy implications.

Performativity: conceptual considerations

The concept of performativity has a varied history in the work of philosophers such as, for example, Austin, Butler, Callon, Lyotard and Barad (Gond et al. 2016; Guérard, Langley, and Seidl 2013). For the purpose of this paper, the approach by Lyotard ([1979] 1984) seems most relevant, since he grounded his concept of performativity in an analysis of the state of scientific knowledge in Western societies (Cowen 2006; Dey and Steyaert 2007). Ball (2000, 2003, 2012) turned this analysis towards a managerial and governance concept of performativity that profoundly influenced the field of education studies (e.g., Acuna 2024; Goodley and Perryman 2022; Hardy and Lewis 2017; Murray 2012; Perryman 2006), and thus holds relevance for understanding management and governance in higher education institutions, such as universities.

Discussing the condition of scientific knowledge in advanced Western societies, Lyotard's central question is: 'where, after the metanarratives, can legitimacy reside' (Lyotard [1979] 1984, xxiv-xxv)? The legitimizing grand narratives of the modern era (e.g., emancipation, capitalism) are no longer convincing and should be treated with 'incredulity.' Instead, in the postmodern era, science has become one of many heterogeneous language games, producing a triptych for alternative legitimation criteria: performativity, consensus, and paralogy (Jones 2003). Of these, performativity emerged as dominant with the advent of research aiding technologies:

> Technical devices ... follow a principle, and it is the principle of optimal performance: maximizing output (the information or modifications obtained) and minimizing input (the energy expended in the process). Technology is therefore a game pertaining not to the true, the just, or the beautiful, etc., but to efficiency (Lyotard [1979] 1984, 44).

Under this principle, science has become enmeshed with the societal socio-economic structure and inequalities: 'an equation between wealth, efficiency and truth is thus established ... science becomes a force of production, in other words, a moment in the circulation of capital' (Lyotard [1979] 1984, 45). The same developments may be observed in education, the transmission of knowledge,

which increasingly has become geared to the needs of business and society, instead of the pursuit of scientific truth:

> The question . . . is no longer 'Is it true?' but 'What use is it?' In the context of the mercantilization of knowledge, more often than not this question is equivalent to: 'Is it saleable?' And in the context of power-growth: 'Is it efficient?' Having competence in a performance-oriented skill does indeed seem saleable in the conditions described above, and it is efficient by definition (Lyotard [1979] 1984, 51).

Ball (2000, 2003, 2012) extended Lyotard's performativity to include not only the societal conditions for the pursuit and transmission of knowledge, but also the managerial and governance prerequisites for such performativity within organizations. Following Lyotard, but also building on the work of Michel Foucault and Judith Butler, Ball regarded performativity as a new mode of state regulation which makes it possible to govern public sector organizations in an 'advanced liberal' way, with 'monitoring systems' and the 'production of information' as central tenets and 'the data-base, the appraisal meeting, the annual review, report writing, the regular publication of results and promotion applications, inspections, and peer reviews' as its central mechanics (Ball 2003, 220). He broadened the definition of performativity as a technology, a culture, and a mode of regulation that:

> . . . employs judgments, comparisons and displays as means of incentive, control, attrition and change based on rewards and sanctions (both material and symbolic). The performances (of individual subjects or organizations) serve as measures of productivity or output, or displays of 'quality,' or 'moments' of promotion or inspection. As such they stand for, encapsulate or represent the worth, quality or value of an individual or organization within a field of judgment. The issue of who controls the field of judgment is crucial (Ball 2003, 216).

As extended in the research by Ball and other educational sociologists, three interrelated aspects of performativity are particularly visible (Jones et al. 2020). The first aspect pertains to *quantification*: the process of abstracting employees into sets of comparable, classifiable, and manageable data or numbers, in a spreadsheet or other numerical control system (Ball 2000, 2003). The resulting performance metrics, benchmarks, key performance indicators, and ratios permit management control through a 'tyranny of numbers,' normalizing individual differences and idiosyncrasies into single numbers and figures that can easily be 'linked to another set of numbers – money – in the form of reward – that is performance-related pay' (Ball 2015, 299).

The second aspect pertains to the *ideal of perfect control* over a system: 'which is supposed to improve its performance, . . . [but] in fact lowers the performance level it claims to raise. This inconsistency explains the weakness of state and socioeconomic bureaucracies: they stifle the systems or subsystems they control and asphyxiate themselves in the process (negative feedback)' (Lyotard [1979] 1984, 55–56). Desired performance improvements in the primary process are negated by the increased organizational time and resources devoted to setting up performance measurement systems, collecting and recording performance data and managing relationships with external regulators. Acquiring information for perfect control: 'consumes so much energy that it drastically reduces the energy available for making improvement inputs' (Ball 2003, 221; Murray 2012).

The third aspect pertains to *fabrication*: versions of (educational) organizations or persons that do not exist but are 'produced purposefully in order "to be accountable." Truthfulness is not the point – the point is their effectiveness, both in the market or for inspection or appraisal, and in the "work" they do "on" and "in" the organization – their transformational and disciplinary impact' (Ball 2003, 224). Here, fabrication has the double connotation of production and forgery. If the financial survival of an organization is dependent on meeting performance standards, audits, and quality marks, then that organization will make every effort to comply, if necessary, by creating parallel accountability realities. Visitations held in the context of audits, accreditations, and excellence exercises thus become a theatrical play, a 'performance' in the literal sense of the word that reinforces the ideal of perfect control of managers and auditors (Acuna 2024; Hardy and Lewis 2017; Perryman 2006).

Performativity in universities and business schools

All three aspects of performativity, as defined in the previous section, return in the literature on university management and organization and provide meaning to the recent historical developments.

The aspect of *quantification* resonates widely in the literature, pointing at the importance of national and international league tables and rankings (e.g., the UK Teaching Excellence and Research Excellence Frameworks). The underlying quantitative performance management policies tend to reduce academic education to 'scores' in student surveys and academic research to abstract publication 'points' in journal ranking systems (Kallio et al. 2016; Tourish and Willmott 2015). This deep internalization of quantified assessment has become so ingrained in the university as to become a 'logic' (Chun and Sauder 2022). This reduction of human subjects to sets of quantitative measures, however, has been condemned in the literature as 'administrative evil' (Dillard and Ruchala 2005), viewing this 'logic' as fundamentally dehumanizing. It has led to predominantly instrumentalizing and coercive performance evaluation, auditing, and accountability policies that may lead to a closed, anxious, and defensive academic working climate (Alvesson and Spicer 2016; De Vita and Case 2016). The purely quantitative assessment of academic education and research generally involves an one-sided form of recognition of academic work that negatively affects the mental well-being of academics. Respondents variously report feelings of shame, anger, failure, loss of self-confidence and even clinical depression, burnout and suicidal tendencies (Knights and Clarke 2014; Ruth et al. 2018; Smith and Ulus 2020).

The aspect of *ideal of perfect control* appears in various forms in the literature. In the past decades, older, more collegial and lateral forms of university administration (when and wherever they did prevail), increasingly have been replaced by authoritarian, top-down, management by 'professional' managers, often corporate outsiders with little or no connection or affinity with academic education and research (Chandler, Barry, and Clark 2002; Parker 2014). These university managers often strengthen their grip on the university by increasing the numbers of administrative personnel, directly under their command, and by redistributing resources from academics to these newly formed admin functions, in such a way that the latter come to oversee the former ('quality control' is often provided as a rationale for this) (Dillard and Tinker 1996; Ross and

Savage 2021). They then use this newly formed administrative power to disregard and replace democratic procedures and channels (frequently through, for example, disingenuous 'consultation' exercises), in order to crack down on resistance and to impose their managerialist view on what is left of the university's collegial nature and culture (Fleming 2022; McCann et al. 2020). Further control of jobs and financial conditions is often achieved by the increasing commercialization of university education and research, catering to business' interest in 'commodified' students and research (Hall 2018; Lynch and Ivancheva 2015). The underlying model of semi-market competition may lead to an increasing precarity of university work, in which more low-paid, temporary workers tend to replace workers with tenured positions and in which academic identities may become insecure and fragile, and thus more amenable to managerial control (Knights and Clarke 2014; Ratle et al. 2020).

The aspect of *fabrication* is highly prevalent in the literature, most clearly in the metaphor of the Academic Potemkin Village, denoting some universities that disproportionally spend their money on marketing, branding, enrollment management, and luxury campus facilities in order to 'look good,' rather than 'be (academically) good.' This may also include creativity in influencing ranking systems, which in their turn are used for further branding and marketing (Lund Dean et al. 2020; Morgan 2022). This all tends to be supported by practices and methods of corporate communication, following which university campuses are flooded with posters and banners, and websites and social media filled with proclamations extolling the virtues and accomplishments of the 'corporate university,' or 'University, Ltd,' and its 'glorious leaders' (Parker 2014; Tuchman 2009).

Furthermore, this aspect returns as the artificial representation of academic research and education accomplishments through systems of performance measurement, quality assurance, and excellence frameworks (Watermeyer 2019). Such systems mostly work on the basis of a cybernetic model that is well suited for the control of routine industrial production processes but does not match the more complex, qualitative, and cognitive nature of academic work (Visser 2016). However, in spite of this mismatch, in the spirit of NPM, academic managers often have pushed on with these cybernetic systems, creating vast administrative staff units to collect and process the many data necessary for 'ideal control.' The effects of such control are not only discernible in the impaired self-image and identity formation of academics (Gendron 2008; Kallio et al. 2016) but also in the fact that, from a certain point on, administrators and managers may create a 'parallel reality,' or fabrication, of academic life that in principle may proceed with or without academics.

The three aspects of performativity, as delineated by Ball (following Lyotard), thus go a long way in accounting for, and critiquing, managerialism, and its effects on universities (Jones et al. 2020). In the next section we briefly discuss methodology and add our own personal narratives, making sense of them and connecting our experiences to the wider literature via the performativity concept.

Method: collaborative autoethnography

Collaborative autoethnography has increasingly been employed in critical studies of academia (e.g., Dyer et al. 2024; Zawadski and Jensen 2020). As such, it adheres to a more general exhortation to engage in 'writing differently' (Gilmore et al. 2019): the free expression of academics' lived emotions, fears,

and feelings under managerialist academic regimes needs different writing practices and standards than those afforded by conventional 'academic writing,' emphasizing distance, rationality, and objectivity (Callahan and Elliott 2020; Ruth et al. 2018; Smith and Ulus 2020). In our case, collaborative autoethnography includes

> joint reflection and critique of personal stories as well as revisiting them through a given conceptual and theoretical lens (...), promot[ing] a way of turning inward that simultaneously enhances our skill at turning outward ... Collaborative autoethnographies encourage us to do this together and they offer a way to go beyond individual storytelling and reflection (Nordbäck, Hakonen, and Tienari 2022, 336).

We are four late-career academics, with different career paths and working at different institutions across the globe (see Table below).

	Age	Gender	Location	Professional Status
Ashok	58	M	Japan	Professor
Max	61	M	Netherlands	Associate Professor
Peter	64	M	UK	Professor
Lynne	60	F	USA	Associate Professor

Over the past 15 years, we have worked together in various combinations on various projects, and we have come to a common understanding and appreciation of what academic work entails and should entail. For this particular paper, thinking already started in early 2017, when Max and Peter (together with Anders Örtenblad) organized a track at a CMS conference in Liverpool on the 'performative university.' The theme quickly caught on and gathered momentum, leading to a well-received special issue of *Management Learning* in 2020. In the wake of this success, it was strongly felt that the particular performativity conception of Ball and Lyotard could be of further use in theorizing about and making sense of the current neoliberal managerialist university. In Autumn 2022, Max therefore invited Ashok, Peter and Lynne to participate, so as to widen the scope of performativity experiences and to diversify narratives. In the course of the past 2 years, we first individually wrote our narratives, guided by our initial individual understanding of the three aspects of performativity and weaving our various cognitive, emotional, and affective experiences around them (Hokka 2023; Tienari 2019). Then, we exchanged our narratives via email and engaged in several rounds of joint reading and reflection, considering the convergent and divergent themes among them (Chang, Ngunjiri, and Hernandez 2016). In engaging in this process, we thus aim to capture the unique experience of each one of us, while simultaneously offering a common thread of understanding and joint sense-making via the concept of performativity and its three aspects.

In the next four sections, our narratives are presented in italics. We employ non-italic font in the accounts wherever we initially felt that the aspects of quantification, the ideal of perfect control and fabrication were germane to our experiences. Thereafter, we connect our narratives to one another and to the literature, in order to exemplify common or uncommon themes among them.

Ashok: performativity of publications

Ashok relates his past and future career experiences inside and outside academia: '*I have over 30 years of experience in managing and leading in Japan-related international business contexts. During these years, I have noticed corporate Japan's gradual evolution from process orientation to serving shareholders (share price monitoring), i.e., a change to results orientation. The same shift can be seen in Japanese public universities which were hived off as university corporations around 2004.*

I have moved only recently to academia. I was motivated to give back to society in the form of research (long-term contribution) and education (immediate contribution to student development). When I applied, one of the advertised requirements was: 'the three publications of greatest relevance should be numbered 1 to 3'. This quantified requirement was my first encounter with quantification *in Japanese academia. Fortunately, I had completed my doctorate as a PhD by Concurrent Publication. Therefore, I had the requisite number of publications to prove my past performance. But, this quantified requirement means I now recommend the PhD by Concurrent publication route to others. Thus,* quantification *suggests that certain choices in decisions, such as path-to-PhD, are better than others.*

In my current university (where I have served over 3 years), I do not encounter the publish-or-peril policies. I am told there is no obligation to publish. The university provides faculty members with research funds. Currently, the funding amount is reduced if there is no publicizable research activity for 3 years. I am told the funding is increased for those considered active – the criteria are not yet clear to me. Nevertheless, this means that there is some performance induced decisioning about who gets less and who gets more research funding, approaching some ideal of perfect control.

Recently, I came across an advertised opening at another Japanese public university that required: 'distinguished academic achievements including a published book and no less than 20 articles (co-authored ones excluded).' I shared my surprise with a veteran professor colleague. My colleague replied: 'these publications do not refer to the quality of journals or even to whether the publication outlet is peer-reviewed. The papers could be published even in the department bulletin.' Thus, one notices a quality vs quantity fabrication *dilemma, in which I, too, am inadvertently trapped. I now understand that the Japanese public university environment prefers single-author publications, but my own preference would be to tap collaborative synergy to produce better quality (co-authored) publications – research outputs that are more meaningful, harking back to my original long-term motivation for the switch to academia.*

Max: performativity of research policies

Max discusses two policies for research assessment in 2008 and 2016 at his faculty at a Dutch university: '*Before 2008, my faculty had an informal research assessment policy in place for two decades, but in 2008 a new policy was introduced, after being broadly discussed within the faculty. This policy distinguished between four levels in journal publications (A, B, C, X), based on a mix of factors such as the ISI impact factor, ranking in the top of an SSCI or SCI category or classification as top or prominent journal by comparable faculties and universities.*

Publication points were awarded on the basis of the A (20), B (10) or C (5) status of the journal, which (together with the book publications) had to add up to 50 points over a period of 5 years for a researcher with a full-time position. The rules and regulations surrounding the implementation of this policy did not contain any measures against researchers with too few publication points. Although it was my first encounter with quantification, *in general I found this policy workable and fair.*

However, this policy came under scrutiny during a research visitation in 2013 because, according to the visitation committee, it did not contain 'real incentives for international quality oriented publishing.' This, and a subsequent benchmark, formed the input for a new policy that took effect in 2016, the so-called Academic Publication Index (API). In this, the Article Influence Percentile was leading, calculated as a forced ranking from 1.0 to 0.01 of Article Influence Scores, exclusively within ISI journals.

The publication points were now awarded on the basis of only five publications (again including books) with the highest AIP scores, which were then added up to an API score per individual researcher. Unlike in the previous policy, clear sanctions (in terms of reduction of research time) were now foreseen for researchers with too low API scores, which sanctions in some cases were actually applied. As chair and member of two influential faculty committees, I tried to change or at least stall this new system, but to no avail.

The 2016 system with its exclusive emphasis on API scores was clearly more quantitative, *leaving less room than the 2008 policy for disciplinary additions and considerations. The* ideal of perfect control *was visible in both policies, directing my performance in a uniform direction, but the 2016 system was far more coercive and comprehensive, routinely reporting the API scores of our publications in the faculty registration system and bringing them up in my yearly performance interview, which I felt as threatening and doing injustice to my research accomplishments.*

Finally, both policies played a major role in fabrication, *inherent in the research visitations of the past decades. In order to deter possible funding agencies as little as possible, a very positive picture of faculty research performance was presented. These were complemented with practice sessions on the days prior to the 'site visits' of the visitation committees, in which I had to rehearse desired texts and behaviors. Also, the faculty vision and mission was hung on the walls and coffee machines for me (and all of us) to read and to memorize, all in the service of an optimal 'performance' in front of those visitation committees.'*

Peter: facing performativity as a manager

Peter talks about his experience as a senior academic manager at a UK faculty and business school: *'I was promoted to Faculty Deputy Dean. This was announced by the University Senior Management Team (USMT) following a typically mishandled delay of 3 months. Also, simultaneously (and to my surprise) USMT stated I would also be appointed Acting Executive Dean with immediate effect to re-energize the Business School. But life as a dean in the UK is about having no real power and being 'battered from pillar to post' by endless accountability for metrics and KPIs – all* quantification.

Without warning, my faculty was subjected twice to invasive mandatory investigations by members of USMT – a flying squad – regarding educational staff/student efficiency (itself a clear measure of quantification). *Prolonged and painful reviews took place, where USMT pilloried*

staff with bullying, harassment and sadistic enjoyment to achieve some perverse ideal of perfect control. *Also, at one point USMT purchased a new external software program that indicated that the Business School had a '2 million-pound deficit.' This prompted another USMT full-blown condemnation and investigation. Of course, within this* fabricated *world it had never existed – rather invented by the algorithm. Finally, after 24 months of investigation, USMT acknowledged (but only in passing) that this was now realized and investigations quietly ended.*

USMT was 'like a medieval barony and castle' overlooking the parochial-minded 'market square' faculties which tried to go about their business – fearful, watchful, mutually untrusting – always one eye on the castle. The Business School remained the scapegoat for criticism (however unjustly) and other faculties hid behind this to lead a quiet life. USMT had a notion of perfect control *but really they were dissolute and chaotic – like an in-fighting court and causing pain and panic in the kingdom.*

At a certain point during my tenure, USMT launched an overly ambitious program of internationalization. In the pursuit of promised riches and income, based on misjudged optimistic forecasts and assuming perfect control *over the external and internal environment, the USMT decided to internationalize rapidly from a zero base. 98% of this activity was carried by the Business School, placing inordinate pressure on its staff. This strategy fused all three elements: exhibiting* control, *money* quantification *and impression management (hence* fabrication*) to the outside world that a high quality, money-making, high-prestige international program was in the making. Any staff challenging these initiatives were sanctioned as 'blockers.'*

My story terminated with an attempt to take back control and dignity from USMT. After yet another terrible meeting, I returned to my office, picked up the phone to the USMT and said: 'I'm calling it in.' This meant I was effectively a 'dead man walking' in the organization and my life was subsequently made unbearable. But I had renegotiated some control of my working life and escaped the continuing pressures of quantification, the ideal of perfect control *and* fabrication.'

Lynne: performativity of rankings

Lynne shares her experiences with a highly publicized rankings scandal that occurred at her business school, on the campus of a large, highly diverse, urban, public, R1 university (a top U.S. research university as classified by the Carnegie Foundation for the Advancement of Higher Education) that was founded on an egalitarian vision in the 19th century as an evening college for the working class: *the Dean of my business school zealously pursued, over a period of 15 years, a highly aspirational strategy to climb the US News & World Report (USNWR) rankings in a number of different business school graduate program categories (itself already a clear sign of* quantification*). To start, he beefed up the prestige of the faculty by hiring highly prolific scholars who were able to publish top journal articles with colleagues and doctoral students to increase the school's research reputation. The Dean's strategy for the school was built on explicit* quantification: *the proliferation of rankings outlets, accountability systems, bibliometrics, and individual scholarly indices – all based entirely on numbers to evaluate every component of school-wide, programmatic, and faculty 'success.' Financial bonuses were given to faculty for research productivity and to admissions staff for increasing program enrollments.*

Soon thereafter, aiming for the ideal of perfect control, *the Dean created a Russian doll set of lesser-titled Deanery and added layers of administrators to oversee faculty and programmatic output. This included many new staff members whose primary purpose was to apply metrics to faculty research production and locate ways to game the discipline-specific and business-school-wide faculty and program rankings outlets. Faculty who didn't meet the standards of this new bureaucratic control were let go or punished by being given higher teaching loads and administrative responsibilities. But by the early 2010s, the strategy had come to fruition: the school's online MBA program was ranked #1 by USNWR for 4 years in a row, resulting in greatly increased enrollments in that program as well as a number of other graduate programs.*

But, in 2018, a whistleblower within the school found a 'clerical error' in the school's rankings submission, which ultimately spiraled into an investigation into the rankings reporting concerning other programs and a withdrawal of the school's ranking data to USNWR. In a clear case of fabrication, *it turned out that data submitted by the school to the USNWR business-school rankings team was intentionally manipulated in ways that made several of the school's programs appear more rigorous in terms of student admission and achievement. The President of the university asked the Dean to resign, he refused and was consequently fired. A team from the U.S. Department of Education, the FBI, and the Postal Inspection Service took several years to unravel the case, ultimately resulting in the indictment and conviction of the Dean (and two staffers) on two counts: wire fraud and conspiracy to commit wire fraud.*

Connecting narratives

The four personal narratives underline our lived experiences of performativity in the university or business school context. They highlight that there are different 'shades of performativity' across the institutions involved, whereby some of us are only slightly touched by aspects of performativity, while others are close to being 'totally administered' (McCann et al. 2020).1

To start, the aspect of *quantification* is experienced differently by each of us. It ranges from publication number requirements in PhD trajectories and job applications by Ashok, to the introduction of a forced ranking research assessment policy within Max's faculty, to the 'endless accountability' for metrics and KPI's experienced by Peter, to Lynne's business school-wide obsession with national rankings and the ways this pervaded its research and education assessment and ranking policies at all levels. Max and, in particular, Peter also relate to the negative feelings associated by being judged, as an employee or manager, in narrow and one-sided ways by quantitative measures only. Our narratives chime in with the literature on university management and governance, discussed earlier, which likewise points at the importance of national rankings, the underlying tendencies to reduce academic teaching and research to easily measurable and scalable metrics and scores, and to the negative feelings and emotions that such one-sided evaluations instill in academics.

The aspect of *ideal of perfect control* also resonates within our experiences. It ranges from Ashok's experience with a somewhat vague faculty policy of financially steering employee performance, to Max's qualms with his faculty's policy of 'routinely reporting' API publication scores in the faculty registration system and

including them in yearly performance interviews, to Peter having to deal with senior managers tightly overseeing 'his' faculty like 'a medieval barony and castle', to Lynne having to do her work under the increasing bureaucratic control of 'a Russian doll set of lesser-titled Deanery and added layers of administrators.' Ashok, Max and Peter also report feelings of uncertainty, threat and indignity in the face of differing attempts at perfect control in their institutions. Our narratives fit in with the literature, discussed earlier, that describes the ascendance to power of 'professional' university managers, sustained by increasing numbers of administrative staff and managerial functions with an eye on controlling and overseeing academics' behavior in the desired managerialist direction. Less visible in our narratives, however, is the control via increased commercialization and competition and the resulting precarity of academic work, which may be due to our late-career status and the protected tenure position that (still) comes with it.

Further, the aspect of *fabrication* is quite visible in our narratives. It ranges from Ashok's surprise discovery that 'papers in the department bulletin' could pass as 'distinguished academic achievements,' to Max's participation in dress rehearsals and practice sessions purported to present an overly positive faculty image during visitation site visits, to Peter's amazement and dislike of the erection of a 'Potemkin village' of international programs from a zero base in his business school, to the wholesale and prolonged provision of forged performance data in order to influence the national ranking of Lynne's business school, ending in a criminal conviction of the Dean involved. Our narratives combine smoothly with the literature discussed earlier, which on the one hand reports on the continuing existence of Academic Potemkin Villages (investing heavily in 'looking good' commercially and marketing-wise at the expense of 'being good' in a real academic sense), and on the other hand shows the existence of a 'parallel reality,' created by managers and administrators in the service of flawless accreditation audits and excellence exercises.

Our narratives also underline how these three aspects of performativity reinforce one another. Quantification renders academic performance increasingly visible and detectable, making it amenable to heightened (perfect) control, which in its turn in due time makes a spreadsheet-based fabrication possible that may (but often may not) conform to the real situation in the university or business school involved. In particular, Lynne's business school provides a telling example of how attainment of a purely quantitative national ranking score led to an increase in administrative and managerial controls in order to have everybody churn out the 'correct' numbers, which in the course of a decade created a 'parallel reality' of school performance that differed enough from its true nature so as to warrant criminal charges.

Finally, Peter makes it clear that higher management positions are not immune to the 'terrors of performativity,' having to deal simultaneously with capricious and overbearing managers and directors higher up in the chain of command, as well as with demotivated and resigned teachers and researchers suspecting and resisting control. His experience draws attention to the replete systemic strength of performativity in his particular situation, in the end leaving even higher management echelons fairly powerless to change systems and policies.

Discussion, conclusion, and policy implications

In this paper, we have adopted the concept of 'performativity' to account for, and critique, neoliberal university policies, and practices. Through collaborative autoethnography, we have added our own personal narratives to 'talk back' to neoliberal managerialism. In this final section, we reflect on the efficacy of our 'talking back' and the influence that we, as late-career academics, have (and should have) asserted on our respective institutions and their policies. We also formulate some policy implications to contravene the three aspects of performativity.

The reflective question boils down to what we, with our combined 100 years of academic service, have done *in practice* to counter the 'terrors of performativity' that we have just repudiated (hopefully) eloquently *on paper* (the irony of which is not lost upon us). It has not gone unnoticed that many academics seem to go along almost effortlessly with irrepressible and relentless managerialist regimes (Alvesson and Spicer 2016; Parker 2018). For example, much of the pain and disarray of NPM and managerialism has been inflicted *by* academics *on other* academics. They (and we as well) have played a role in audits, visitations, excellence exercises, funding schemes, and so on, all activities immediately coming to an end when academics like ourselves would collectively refuse to partake in them anymore (Dillard and Tinker 1996; Lorenz 2012).

On the other hand, our narratives do help to understand how the feelings and emotions aroused by oppression and misrecognition may be a strong source of academic resistance, activism, and resilience. The specific attempts by Max and Peter to battle performative evaluation and management practices at their own faculties ultimately proved unsuccessful, but all of us have at one point engaged in other protest or resistance activities, ranging from union meetings and strikes, to actions via workers' councils, to policy change attempts via faculty boards and committees. Academics (like us) in fact can apply many tactics to survive under managerialism and to battle the system, ranging from open protest, symbolic compliance, avoidance to quietly 'throwing sand' in the administrative machine (Anderson 2008; Contu 2018; Teelken 2012).

However, individual resistance must be joined by collective efforts, directed at lasting education policy changes. In this way, we not only can 'talk back' to managerialism but also to the NPM-inspired political and administrative policies that gave rise to it. Following our three aspects of performativity, here we propose three 'counter-performative' policies (cf. Boedker, Chong, and Mouritsen 2020), for which some positive support can be found in recent international examples.

Our first policy proposal is to counter quantification, by basing hiring, promotion, and funding decisions no longer only on metrics, but also on the scientific content and quality of the applications and proposals involved. This is supported by the San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment (DORA), developed by the American Society for Cell Biology (ASCB) in San Francisco in December 2012 and since then signed by 3,271 organizations and 21,996 individuals across the world.2 The declaration calls to end: 'the use [of] journal-based metrics, such as Journal Impact Factors, as a surrogate measure of the quality of individual research articles, to assess an individual scientist's contributions, or in hiring, promotion, or funding decisions.' Instead, universities, funding agencies, and assessment committees should primarily consider the 'scientific content' of articles and proposals. Following up on this, all Dutch universities, knowledge organizations, and

funding agencies signed DORA in 2019, and subsequently have developed new policies directed at a more balanced 'recognition and reward' of academic work, including education, team contributions, and societal impact.3

Our second policy proposal is to counter the ideal of perfect control, by decentralizing decision-making, curbing the numbers of managerial and admin staff, and easing the impact of comprehensive performance measurement and budgeting systems, all with an eye on toning down evaluative and financial pressures on academic employees. This is supported by the recent critique and scrutiny at U.S. universities of Responsibility Centered Management (RCM) – a corporate-inspired budgeting system that demands that each academic and research unit at the university tightens its budget in order to meet its own 'bottom line' and at the same time allows central administration to spend profligately without much accountability and transparency (Levin, Martin, and Lopez-Damian 2020; Rutherford and Rabovsky 2018). Faculty unions and senates today are calling out the discrepancies between university spending and the public outcry over student outcomes, forcing administrations to unveil what is behind the smokescreen of this corporate-centered budgeting model (Morgan 2022; Wagner, Kulbaga, and Cohen 2017). Further, it is supported by policy changes at Ghent University in Belgium, which eased the evaluative pressure on its academic staff (from yearly to five-year performance appraisals), enlarged the scope of these appraisals from only research output to broader goals of talent development, growth, and contribution to society, and drastically curtailed the administrative burden on academics.4

Our third policy proposal is to counter fabrication, by cutting back considerably on the numbers of different audits, accreditation, and excellence exercises that universities have to go through, liberating universities from the forced creation of 'parallel realities' in order to remain 'accredited' or 'excellent' and in the process freeing up considerable resources to make real, meaningful changes in the service of education and research. This is not yet supported by examples from the real world, although a humble beginning was made when in 2022 the European Commission, Science Europe, and the European University Association drafted an Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment, requiring: 'basing assessment primarily on qualitative judgement, for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators.'5 This provides an impetus for European universities to adopt more balanced policies of research appraisal and career advancement that require less window dressing in the service of some ill-conceived and unattainable 'excellence' ideal.

While our policy proposals still await implementation in large parts of the academic world, the underlying examples provide some glimmering hope that at least parts of the academic world are now moving in more humanist and enlightened directions. Will all this be sufficient to enact lasting policy changes that help to alleviate academic hardship? As late-career academics, we hope so, and we will further work towards change. Although our remaining time in academia is slowly running out, we still occupy positions of relative security and seniority, from which we are far better positioned to resist performativity and push for change than many early and mid-career colleagues. Written 'differently' (Gilmore et al. 2019), our current (predis)position is well expressed in this famous poem by Dylan Thomas:

Do not go gentle into that good night,

Old age should burn and rave at close of day;
Rage, rage against the dying of the light.

Notes

1. These 'shades of performativity' hang together with national differences between our four countries. Comparative analyses of government systems have indicated that 'NPM penetrated furthest in Anglo-American countries and Scandinavia … Countries with a strong state and a high-prestige bureaucracy, for example Germany, Japan, and Spain made less progress in implementing the new philosophy,' with the Netherlands somewhere in between (Hague and Harrop 2010, 358; Pollitt and Bouckaert 2011). Comparative research on systems of higher education also found that the US and UK were generally most 'managerialist,' followed at a short distance by the Netherlands and at a long distance by Japan (Fukudome 2019; Levin, Martin, and Lopez-Damian 2020; Teelken 2012).
2. https://sfdora.org/signers/. (accessed 1 August 2024).
3. https://recognitionrewards.nl/. (accessed 1 August 2024).
4. https://www.ugent.be/en/work/mobility-career/career-aspects/professorial-staff/overview.htm. (accessed 1 August 2024).
5. https://www.scienceeurope.org/our-resources/agreement-reforming-research-assessment/. (accessed 1 August 2024).

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